

Chapter 2: The Men Who Made People Into Parts

The Installation

Chapter One described the lie – the machine metaphor, the projection of factory logic onto life itself. But a lie does not infect a civilization by accident. Someone has to fund it. Someone has to build the infrastructure that carries it into every school, every hospital, every office, every mind. The machine metaphor did not drift into American life like pollen on the wind. It was installed. Deliberately, systematically, with specific money from specific men for a specific purpose.

This chapter names the men. This chapter follows the money. This chapter is the receipts.

The General Education Board

In 1903, John D. Rockefeller founded the General Education Board. The name sounds benign – who could object to a board dedicated to education? But the board was not dedicated to education. It was dedicated to producing a workforce. And the difference between those two things is the difference between a garden and a factory floor.

Frederick T. Gates, Rockefeller's chief business advisor, wrote the board's vision in what was called Occasional Letter Number One, published in

1906. The passage deserves to be read in full, because it says the quiet part at a volume that should have shattered windows:

"In our dream we have limitless resources, and the people yield themselves with perfect docility to our molding hand. The present educational conventions fade from our minds; and, unhampered by tradition, we work our own good will upon a grateful and responsive rural folk. We shall not try to make these people or any of their children into philosophers or men of learning or of science. We are not to raise up from among them authors, orators, poets, or men of letters. We shall not search for embryo great artists, painters, musicians. Nor will we cherish even the humbler ambition to raise up from among them lawyers, doctors, preachers, politicians, statesmen, of whom we now have ample supply."

Read it again. This is not a conspiracy theory pulled from a fringe website. This is the General Education Board's own publication, written by the personal advisor to the richest man in America, describing in plain language the purpose of the educational system his employer was funding. The purpose was not to cultivate philosophers, artists, scientists, poets, or statesmen. The purpose was to mold a grateful and responsive folk who would yield with perfect docility.

The purpose was to produce parts.

The model they funded was already waiting. It had been imported from Prussia decades earlier by Horace Mann, who traveled to the German states in the 1840s and returned convinced that the Prussian system of compulsory schooling was the future of American education. The Prussian system had not been designed to cultivate the mind. It had been designed after Napoleon's defeat of Prussia at the Battle of Jena in 1806, when the Prussian state concluded that its population was too independent, too free-thinking, too ungovernable to be reliable in war. The solution was a school system engineered to produce three things: obedient soldiers, obedient workers, and obedient citizens. The architecture of this system is still visible in every public school in America: a bell that starts and stops

activity, identical desks in rows facing a single authority, age-segregated groups moving in lockstep through a standardized curriculum, compliance measured by standardized tests, deviation punished as disruption.

Look at a factory floor. Look at a classroom. The architecture is identical. One authority figure at the front. Identical stations in rows. A bell that controls movement. A product that enters raw, moves down the line, and exits stamped with a grade that declares it complete. The student is the product. The teacher is the floor manager. The administration is corporate. The bell is the shift whistle. The diploma is the quality control sticker that says this unit has been processed and is ready for installation in the workforce.

Rockefeller's money did not invent this system. Rockefeller's money scaled it. The General Education Board spent over \$129 million between 1903 and 1964 – hundreds of millions in today's dollars – reshaping American education in the image of the factory. They funded teacher training programs that taught the Prussian model. They funded school construction that built the factory architecture. They funded curricula that emphasized compliance, memorization, and the standardized reproduction of approved answers over independent thought, creativity, and the capacity to ask questions that had not been pre-approved by the board.

The result was not an education system. It was a human manufacturing plant. And the product it manufactured was not a thinking person. It was a person shaped to yield with perfect docility to the molding hand.

The Flexner Report

In 1910, a schoolteacher named Abraham Flexner published a report that would reshape American medicine for the next century. Flexner was not a doctor. He had no medical training, no clinical experience, no background in the healing arts. He was an educator – a product of the same

institutional thinking that was reshaping the schools – and he was commissioned by the Carnegie Foundation for the Advancement of Teaching, with Rockefeller money waiting in the wings, to inspect the medical schools of the United States and Canada and determine which ones should survive.

Flexner visited 155 medical schools. His report recommended that most of them be closed. The schools that survived were the ones that adopted what Flexner called the “scientific” model – which meant, in practice, the mechanistic model. The body as a machine. Disease as a malfunction of a part. Treatment as a chemical or surgical intervention targeted at the broken component. Diagnosis as identification of the faulty mechanism. The doctor as mechanic. The patient as the machine on the lift.

The schools that did not adopt this model were defunded and shuttered. These included the eclectic medical schools, which taught a broad range of therapeutic traditions. The homeopathic schools, which treated the patient as a whole system rather than a collection of parts. The osteopathic schools, which understood the body as an integrated living structure. The herbal and naturopathic traditions, which worked with the body’s own capacity to heal rather than overriding it with external chemicals. The medical traditions practiced by Black physicians and women physicians, who were disproportionately trained at the schools Flexner recommended closing.

Five of the seven Black medical schools in America were closed following the Flexner Report. The number of medical schools in the country dropped from 155 to 31. The surviving schools were the ones that aligned with the mechanistic model – and the ones that received Rockefeller and Carnegie funding to implement it. Between 1910 and 1930, Rockefeller’s philanthropic organizations poured over \$100 million into the medical schools that survived Flexner’s inspection. The money was not neutral. The money carried an architecture. The architecture was the machine.

And here is the detail that makes the pattern unmistakable: John D. Rockefeller's fortune came from Standard Oil. Standard Oil's byproducts – the petrochemicals left over from refining crude – became the raw material for the pharmaceutical industry. The same man whose money reshaped medical education to favor chemical intervention over holistic treatment was the man whose industrial empire produced the chemicals that the reshaped medical system would prescribe. The mechanic and the parts supplier were the same person.

The result is the medical system you know. The fifteen-minute appointment. The symptom checklist. The prescription pad. The body treated as a collection of independent systems – cardiology for the heart, neurology for the brain, gastroenterology for the gut – as though a human being were an automobile with separate departments for engine, transmission, and electrical. The patient who says *I feel wrong in a way I cannot name* and the doctor who says *your labs are normal* – because the labs measure parts, and the wrongness is in the relationship between the parts, and the system has no instrument for measuring relationship. The system was not designed to see the whole. The system was designed to see the machine.

Among the traditions pushed to the margins by this reshaping was Christian Science. Founded by Mary Baker Eddy in 1879, Christian Science rejected the machine model of the body at its root. The body was not a mechanism to be repaired with chemicals. The body was an expression of Mind – of the divine intelligence that organized life from within, not from without. Healing was not the correction of a mechanical fault. Healing was the restoration of alignment between the living being and the source that animated it. You did not fix the body the way you fixed an engine. You restored the conditions under which the body's own wholeness could express itself. Whether you accept every tenet of Christian Science or not, the framework stands in direct opposition to the Rockefeller model: it begins from the premise that people are alive, not that people are machines.

This matters to the Clokey story in a way that has never been told.

Charles Farrington - Art Clokey's father, my great-great-grandfather - was a Christian Scientist. The rejection of the factory model of the human body was not something Art absorbed from the counterculture or discovered in a college seminar. It was in the household he was born into. Before Art ever touched clay, before he studied under Vorkapich at USC, before he added the name Premavision to his studio after a Sanskrit word for universal love - before any of it - he was the son of a man who believed that human beings were not machines to be fixed but living expressions of something the machine could not see.

Art was orphaned young. Charles died, and Art's mother could not care for him. He was adopted by Joseph Walden Clokey, a music composer at USC, and the world he grew up in was already being rebuilt by Rockefeller money. The schools were already factories. The hospitals were already mechanic shops. The culture was already learning to see itself as a system of parts. And Art, carrying his father's rejection of the machine model in his blood, responded by creating the most anti-machine character in American media history.

Gumby is made of clay. Not plastic. Not digital. Not manufactured on a line. Shaped by human hands, one frame at a time, in a process that is as far from the assembly line as a creative act can be. Clay is soft. Clay transforms. Clay does not hold a permanent shape - it *becomes*. It yields to the hand and then holds whatever form love gives it. Gumby is not a product stamped from a mold. Gumby is what you get when the grandson of a Christian Scientist, carrying four generations of resistance to the machine metaphor, sits down with the most alive material he can find and says: *I will make something that moves*.

The Blockheads - Gumby's villains - are the opposite. Red. Flat. Geometric. Rigid. They are blocks. They are the factory. They are the parts that cannot transform, cannot grow, cannot walk into a book and come out changed. They are the Rockefeller model given a face and a

name. And Gumby defeats them not with force but with flexibility – with the capacity to become something they cannot become, to enter spaces they cannot enter, to transform in ways the rigid cannot transform.

Art did not know he was encoding the Clokey lineage's four-generation war against the machine metaphor into a children's show. Creators rarely know the full weight of what they carry. But the code was there. In the clay. In the *Prema*. In the green figure that bends where the Blockheads break.

Charles Farrington rejected the machine model of the body. Art Clokey rejected the machine model of creativity. Joe Clokey rejected the machine model of business. And the Living Age rejects the machine model of everything – of education, of healthcare, of governance, of the living world itself. Four generations. One refusal. The same refusal, expressed in different material, facing the same enemy in different form.

The Flexner Report did not just reshape medicine in the abstract. It reshaped the world that this family was born into and has been pushing against ever since.

The Taylor Principle

The factory model did not stop at schools and hospitals. It was a universal acid – it dissolved every institution it touched into the same shape.

In 1911, Frederick Winslow Taylor published *The Principles of Scientific Management*. Taylor's thesis was simple and devastating: the worker is a component in a system, and the system can be optimized by studying the component's movements and eliminating all unnecessary motion. Taylor stood over workers with a stopwatch. He measured the time it took to lift a shovel. He calculated the optimal weight of each load. He determined the exact number of shovelfuls per hour that constituted maximum efficiency. He reduced the human body to a set of mechanical operations

and then optimized those operations the way an engineer optimizes a machine – by removing everything that did not contribute to throughput.

Taylor did not see workers. Taylor saw parts. And the parts were interchangeable. If a part wore out, you replaced it. If a part was slow, you retrained it or discarded it. The part had no interior life that mattered to the system. The part had no creativity, no judgment, no wisdom that the system needed. The system needed the part to move in the prescribed way at the prescribed speed for the prescribed duration. Everything else was waste.

Two years later, Henry Ford applied Taylor's principles to the assembly line. The result was the Model T – and the model for every institution that followed. The human being as a station on the line. Fixed in place. Performing a single repetitive operation. Valued for speed and consistency. Replaceable by any other human being trained to perform the same operation. The worker did not need to understand the whole. The worker needed to perform the part. Understanding was the engineer's job. The part just needed to move.

This logic – Taylor's logic, Ford's logic, Rockefeller's logic – metastasized into everything. Cities were zoned into grids: residential here, commercial there, industrial over there, the human life segmented into functions the way the factory segments production. Agriculture became monoculture: one crop, one field, maximum yield, the soil as a production input rather than a living system. Prisons became warehouses: bodies stored in cells, processed through intake, maintained at minimum cost, the human being as inventory. Mental health became mechanical: the brain is broken, identify the malfunction, apply the chemical, adjust the dosage. The patient is not a person in pain. The patient is a machine with a faulty neurotransmitter level.

Every institution touched by this logic took the same shape. The shape of the factory. The shape of the machine. The shape that treats living things

as parts to be managed by a central authority that understands the blueprint they do not.

The Design Error That Requires the State

Here is where the factory model becomes a political theology.

If people are machines, they need a mechanic. Machines do not self-organize. Machines do not adapt to changing conditions. Machines do not differentiate based on context, do not self-repair, do not grow toward what they are meant to become. Machines sit inert until an external force – an engineer, an operator, a controller – activates them and directs their function. Without the controller, the machine does nothing. Without the engineer, the machine has no purpose. Without the central authority, the parts are just parts – disconnected, inert, meaningless.

This is the statist premise, and it is never stated as a premise because stating it plainly would reveal its absurdity. The statist does not say *I believe people are machines*. The statist says *people need to be managed*. The statist says *without regulation, there would be chaos*. The statist says *someone has to be in charge*. But every one of these statements rests on the same hidden foundation: the assumption that people cannot self-organize. That without a central controller, human beings would sit inert, purposeless, unable to coordinate, unable to create, unable to find their function within the whole.

This assumption is the machine metaphor applied to society. And it is wrong for the same reason the machine metaphor is wrong when applied to biology: because people are not machines. People are living things. And living things do not need a central controller. Living things self-organize.

A cell in your body does not receive orders from a CEO cell. It reads its environment – the signals from neighboring cells, the chemical gradients in its context, the position it occupies in the tissue – and it differentiates

accordingly. The same genome produces a neuron, a muscle cell, a skin cell, an immune cell. Not because a central authority assigned each cell its role, but because each cell interpreted its context and became what the context required. No foreman. No org chart. No five-year plan. The intelligence is distributed. The coordination is emergent. The order is real – spectacularly, breathtakingly real – but it was not imposed from above. It arose from within.

An ecosystem does not need a bureau of forest management to decide which species goes where. The forest self-organizes through relationship – through competition and cooperation, through mycorrhizal networks that redistribute resources, through predator-prey dynamics that regulate population, through succession patterns that build complexity over time. The result is a system more resilient, more adaptive, more productive, and more beautiful than anything a central planner could design. Not because no one is in charge, but because *everyone is in charge of their part* – and the whole emerges from the interaction of the parts, not from the command of a controller.

A free market – a genuinely free market, not the crony system that wears the name – works the same way. Entrepreneurs read their context. They see a need that is not being met – a gap where something living should be growing – and they move to fill it. Prices signal. Resources flow. Specialization emerges. Coordination happens not because someone planned it but because millions of living agents are reading their environment and responding. This is what Hayek called spontaneous order, and it is not a metaphor borrowed from biology. It *is* biology. The economy is an ecosystem. The entrepreneur is a cell differentiating in response to its context. The market is a living system that self-organizes – unless a central controller disrupts the signaling by imposing commands that override the local information.

The state is the institutional expression of the machine metaphor applied to human beings. If people are parts, they need an assembler. If people are components, they need an engineer. If people are machines, they need

a central controller to tell them what to do, when to do it, and how to do it – because machines, left to themselves, do nothing. The entire architecture of the modern state – compulsory education to program the parts, licensed healthcare to maintain the parts, regulation to control the parts, taxation to fuel the machine, bureaucracy to manage the throughput – all of it rests on the assumption that human beings are inert matter requiring external activation.

Remove that assumption and the architecture has no foundation.

The Living Correction

The antidote to the factory model is not a better factory. It is the recognition that people were never parts to begin with.

If people are living things – and they are, this is not philosophy but biology – then they do not need a central controller. They need conditions. The gardener does not command the seed to grow. The gardener creates the conditions under which the seed grows itself: good soil, adequate water, sufficient light, protection from what would destroy it before it can root. The seed carries its own instructions. The seed knows what it is meant to become. The gardener's job is not to program the seed but to clear the path between the seed and its own becoming.

Apply this to education: the child is not raw material to be shaped on the assembly line. The child is a seed carrying a code that no curriculum committee wrote. The child will differentiate based on context – based on what they encounter, what captures their attention, what problems they are allowed to wrestle with, what mentors they find along the way. The Montessori method understood this a century ago: the child's work is self-directed, the environment is prepared but not programmed, the teacher observes and assists rather than commands. The apprenticeship model understood this for millennia: you learn by doing, in relationship, in context, at your own pace, with a master who cultivates rather than

commands. Both of these models produce people who can think. The factory model produces people who can comply. The difference is the difference between a forest and a parking lot.

Apply this to healthcare: the body is not a machine with broken parts. The body is a living system with disrupted conditions. Functional medicine asks *why is this system producing this symptom* rather than *which chemical suppresses this symptom*. The question is not *what is broken* but *what is the body trying to do, and what is preventing it from doing it?* The body heals itself – this is not alternative medicine, this is basic biology. Every wound you have ever recovered from healed because your body's living systems repaired the damage without a mechanic. The doctor's job, properly understood, is the gardener's job: create the conditions under which the body's own intelligence can restore itself.

Apply this to governance: the citizen is not a unit to be managed. The citizen is a living agent capable of reading their context and responding. The neighborhood does not need a zoning board to tell it what to become. The neighborhood will self-organize around the needs of the people who live there – if the conditions allow it. The economy does not need a central plan. The economy will coordinate itself through the signals of free exchange – if the signals are not jammed by the interventions of a controller who believes the parts cannot function without commands.

The Rockefeller model said: people are machines, and we are the engineers.

The Living Age says: people are alive, and the engineer was never needed.

The Root, Not the Branch

This is why the Rockefeller system cannot be reformed. You cannot reform a factory into a garden. You cannot add a creativity module to the assembly line and call it education. You cannot add a fifteen-minute

mindfulness session to the mechanistic healthcare model and call it holistic. You cannot add a citizen participation portal to the surveillance state and call it democracy. These are branches. The root is the metaphor. The root is the assumption that people are parts.

Change the metaphor and every institution built on it must be rebuilt from the foundation. Not reformed. Not updated. Not given a fresh coat of paint over the same Prussian architecture. Rebuilt – on the assumption that people are alive, that living things self-organize, that the intelligence is distributed, that the gardener’s job is to create conditions and not to command outcomes.

This is not an abstract philosophical position. This is a design specification. And the design has already been tested – by four billion years of living systems that self-organized without a central controller, that adapted without a five-year plan, that produced complexity and beauty and resilience that no factory has ever matched.

The Rockefeller blueprints are not wrong because they were written by a bad man. They are wrong because they were written for a machine, and we are not machines. We are alive. And the system designed for machines is killing what is alive in us – in our children sitting in rows, in our patients reduced to labs, in our citizens processed as cases, in our workers optimized as components.

The factory bell rings. The living thing inside the uniform still hears the music.

The lie was not an accident. It was an installation. Specific men. Specific money. Specific purpose: to make living things behave like parts.

The school bell is the factory whistle. The prescription pad is the repair order. The org chart is the assembly diagram. The ballot is the quality control survey.

But the child in the desk is not a part. The patient in the gown is not a machine. The citizen in the booth is not a component.

They are alive. And alive things do not need engineers. They need gardeners.

The first correction is not a policy. It is a recognition: we were never machines. We were seeds. And the men who made us into parts were not engineers. They were the drought.